

UX- DESIGN CASE STUDY

NATASHA TUPPER

HMW create leadership opportunities for Indigenous youth themselves so that they can define what culture and belonging looks like for their generation

THE CHALLENGE

1.

Our team began by exploring a significant challenge identified through research: many Indigenous youth, particularly those raised outside of their traditional communities or living in urban environments, experience uncertainty about where they belong. These experiences can contribute to social stigma, discrimination, and a diminished sense of cultural identity and pride. Using the Design Thinking process, we worked to better understand the needs of our users, challenge our initial assumptions, and reframe the problem. Through collaborative ideation and user-centred discussions, we developed the guiding question: "How might we create leadership opportunities for Indigenous youth themselves so that they can define what culture and belonging look like for their generation?"

THE PROCESS

2.

With our "How Might We" statement established, we defined a set of research goals to better understand the experiences, needs, and challenges of Indigenous youth. To gather meaningful insights, our team designed and distributed a user survey, receiving responses from 10 participants. After collecting the data, we conducted an affinity mapping exercise to identify common themes, patterns, and recurring pain points. By organizing similar responses into meaningful groups, we uncovered key insights that informed our understanding of user needs. These findings guided the development of our research goals, which became the foundation for the design decisions made throughout the remainder of the project.

THE RESULTS

3.

We designed a virtual platform centred on accessibility, connection, and leadership development for Indigenous youth. The platform allows users to register for live workshops where they can engage with peers, Elders, mentors, and community members in real time, fostering meaningful connections and shared learning experiences.

Recognizing that not all users can attend live sessions, we also included the option to access downloadable pre-recorded workshops, allowing participants to learn at their own pace and on their own schedule.

To further support personal growth and community connection, we incorporated a mentorship feature that enables youth to connect with mentors for guidance, encouragement, and leadership development.

With these core features defined, we translated our ideas into low-fidelity wireframes. This allowed us to explore the platform's structure, user flows, and information architecture early in the design process, ensuring the experience aligned with both user needs and our project goals before moving into higher-fidelity designs.

As an aspiring UX designer, this experience strengthened my skills in user research, affinity mapping, accessibility, information architecture, wireframing, prototyping, and iterative design. More importantly, it highlighted the responsibility of designing inclusive digital experiences that amplify community voices rather than speaking for them. The result is a platform that supports connection, encourages cultural pride, and provides Indigenous youth with meaningful opportunities to learn, lead, and belong.